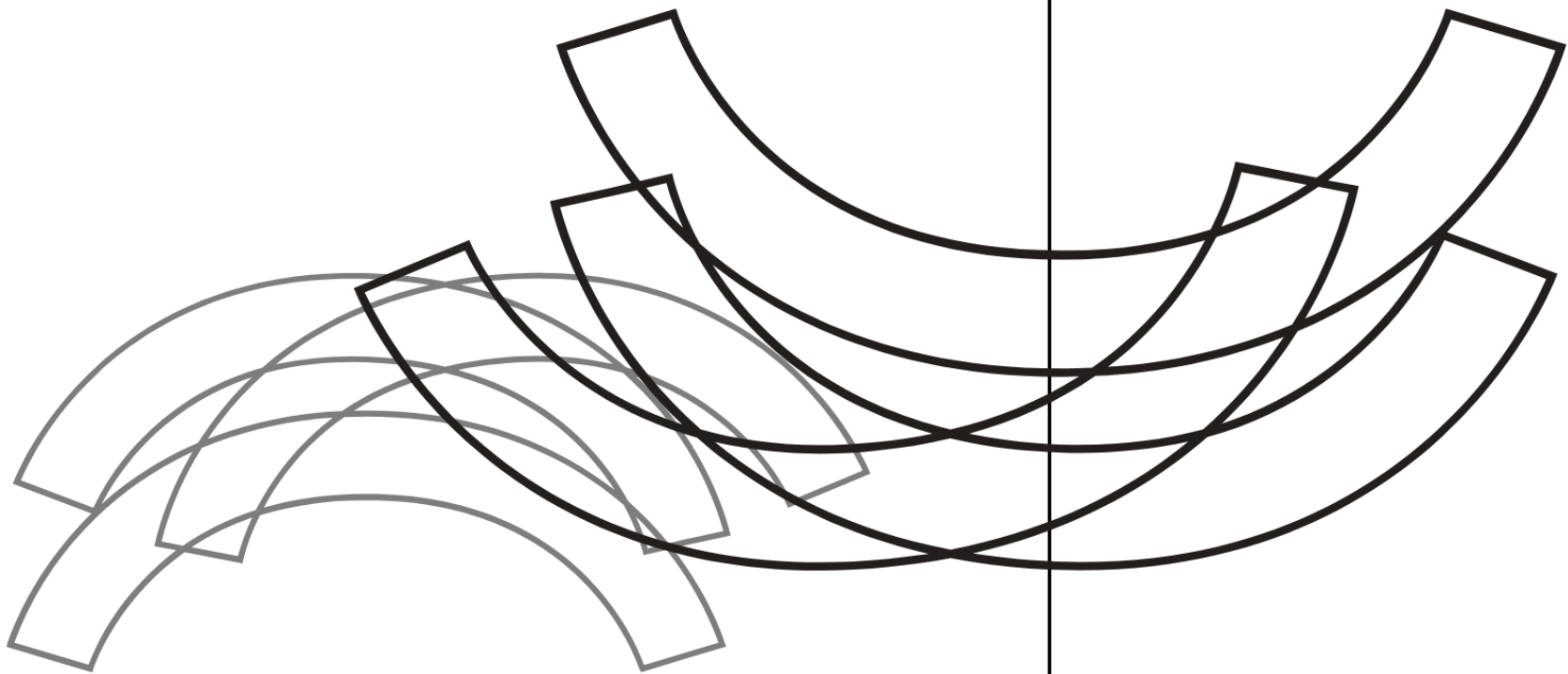


seedling pages
WORKBOOK



therapeuticstudio.ca

Gratitude

These pages grow out of Other Bodies and Make Space, and out of years of photographing the plants I live alongside.

They also sit within a lineage of the healing mark, and three teachers are present in them. Shauna Kaendo and the ohHEY Creative Care Community taught me the principle this work is built on: that making marks together — in community, with breath and rhythm and no image to complete — is itself a form of care, and that we heal alongside one another rather than alone. Behind that practice stand two teachers I have never met. Florence Cane, nearly a century ago, showed that a freeing line begins not in the hand but in the breath and the whole moving body, and understood the scribble as a path to the unconscious. Resmaa Menakem, whose somatic work attends to what the body carries — including what it has inherited — meets that material in the body itself, and pairs each practice with the written mark he calls “soul scribing.” I claim no mastery of what any of them teach; these pages simply learn from all three, with gratitude.

Older practices

The folded box is an old one. Paperfolders in Japan and in Europe have made it for generations, and today it is known by a Japanese name, masu. The thought that paper might go back to the soil came to me from the Green Newspaper, printed by the Mainichi in Japan on 4 May 2016.

And the shape of the practice — make with care, return most of it, keep a little — has elders far older than this workbook, among them the sand mandalas of Tibetan Buddhism. That practice is sacred and it is theirs; I name it as a student, and claim no part of it.

About Seedling Pages

Seedling Pages is a creative care practice from Therapeutic Studio. Each page is attended to, folded into a small pot, and sown with seed that belongs where you live. One strip of each page stays, and the strips are woven. The seed is treated here as another body worth attending to: one that knows a great deal about waiting, and can keep an unfinished feeling company.

This workbook is not a diagnostic tool, a therapeutic assessment, or a replacement for professional mental health support. It is a creative care practice — a way of tending to yourself through attention, making, and the quiet company of the natural world. If you are working with difficult emotions and would like more support, please reach out to a qualified therapist or counsellor.

What this workbook is

Nine pages. Each is a line drawing made very close to a plant — close enough that it stops being a picture of anything and becomes a surface to stay with.

You attend to a page with whatever you have: pencil, watercolour, ink, nothing but your eyes. Then the page is folded into a small pot, filled with soil, and sown. One strip of each page stays with you. When you have a few, you weave them.

There is nothing to complete. Use one page or all nine. Stay inside the lines, cross them, or leave them bare. You are the one investigating, and the making is how you find out.

Arriving

Before you begin, you might take a moment to arrive in your body.

Feel the weight of yourself in your seat. Notice what is touching what — hands on the table, feet on the floor. Take one breath that is slightly slower than usual. Ask yourself, without needing a precise answer: what am I carrying right now?

This is enough. You have already begun.

The companions

Every page began as a photograph of a plant I have lived beside. I drew each one, and then drew the drawing, moving closer each time, until what was left was a small part of a body seen from very near.

They have no names here. We are too close to them for names. You will not be told which plant this is, or which part, or what it means. You know it the way you know anything held close: by looking, and by staying.

So these are companions, not pictures. Before you pick anything up, let your eyes travel a page. Notice where the lines crowd and where they open. Notice where you want to go first.

Then attend to it however this moment needs. Fill one small shape and stop. Follow a single line with your pencil from edge to edge. Flood it. Leave most of it alone. Nothing here asks you to remember or explain anything. Whatever arrives is welcome, and nothing has to arrive.

A note on the seed

Consider the seed. It is a whole plant, very small, packed beside the food it will need and closed inside a coat. The coat keeps water out, and so the seed waits — not because nothing is alive in it, but because the time is not yet right. The waiting is part of how it lives.

When water does come in, what was paused begins to work again. And the first thing to leave the seed is not a leaf. It is the root. Before anything shows above the soil, the seed has already gone further down into the dark and taken hold there.

When you fold your page and press a seed into it, you are giving the page to that. In time the drawing is no longer separate from the ground. Nothing has been thrown away. It has been taken in.

As you sow, notice what in you is waiting, and whether waiting might be something other than being stuck. Notice what has begun in you below the surface, before there is anything to show for it.

Three movements

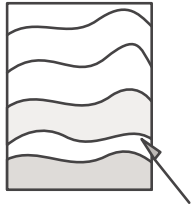
Notice. Choose a page and print only that one, on plain uncoated paper at full size. Look before you touch it.

Make. Attend to the page in whatever way you need, and let it dry. Fold the corner across, wet the crease, and tear away the strip. Fold the square into its box, fill it with soil, and sow.

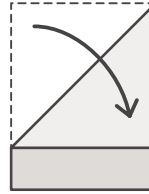
Rest. Keep the strip somewhere you will find it. When you have a few, weave them, over and under, and sit with what they have become before you decide what you think of it.

The practice, in nine pictures

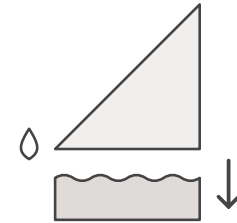
NOTICE · MAKE · REST



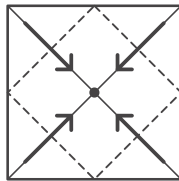
1 Attend to the whole page. Let it dry.



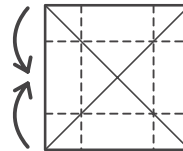
2 Fold the top corner across until the edges meet.



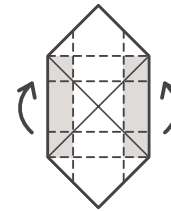
3 Wet the crease and tear. Keep the strip.



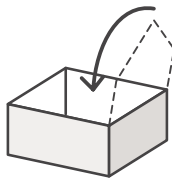
4 Open the square. Crease the other diagonal, then bring all four corners to the centre.



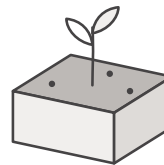
5 Fold each edge to the centre, then open it again. All four.



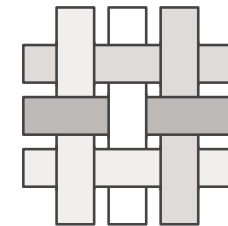
6 Open two opposite flaps. Stand the two long sides up.



7 Lift each end. The corners tuck in; fold the point down inside.



8 Fill with soil. Sow seed native to where you live.



9 When you are ready, weave your strips, over and under.

Raising the walls, in pictures six and seven, takes a try or two. Fold one box from the blank page at the back first.

Sowing

Seed that belongs. Sow seed native to where you live, from a source near you. The Seed Atlas at seedlingpages.ca gives a season and a place to ask for a first set of regions.

Your own ground. Plant the pot in your own garden, a container, or a place you have been invited to plant. Parks and wild places are not ours to add to.

What goes into the ground. A page marked in pencil, watercolour, ink or plant dye can be planted whole. If you used acrylic, permanent marker, wax crayon or anything plastic, lift the seedling out when you plant it and keep the paper.

The weaving

Lay some strips side by side and weave the others through them. On Letter paper, six strips, three each way, make a square about 19 cm (7½ in) across; on A4, four strips make one about 17 cm. For a finer weave, fold each strip in half along its length and tear it in two:

PAGES	WEAVE	LETTER	A4
2	2 by 2	6.4 cm · 2½ in	8.7 cm
3	3 by 3	9.5 cm · 3¾ in	13.1 cm
4	4 by 4	12.7 cm · 5 in	17.4 cm
6	6 by 6	19.1 cm · 7½ in	—

What the research does and does not show

Two small studies found that colouring a mandala lowered anxiety over a short sitting, more than colouring a plaid pattern or a blank page. They say nothing about grief, trauma, or lasting change, and this workbook claims none of those. The American Art Therapy Association supports colouring “for pleasure and self-care” and asks that it not be confused with art therapy delivered by a credentialed therapist. This workbook is an expressive art activity, offered peer to peer.

The longer notes, with links, are at seedlingpages.ca/knowning-seed.html. The nine pages follow as they are finished; each is printed on its own upright sheet. The last sheet here is a blank page with the fold lines, for a first box.

Sources

- **The seed.** How Seeds Work, Jeff Schalau, University of Arizona Cooperative Extension, Yavapai County (2007). cales.arizona.edu/yavapai/anr/hort/byg/archive/howseedswork.html
- **The fold.** History of the Blintz Box, David Mitchell, The Public Paperfolding History Project. origamiheaven.com/historyoftheblintzbox.htm
- **Paper that returns.** The newspaper that gives back to the Earth — literally, One Earth. oneearth.org/the-newspaper-that-gives-back-to-the-earth-literally
- **Colouring.** Curry, N. A., & Kasser, T. (2005). Can Coloring Mandalas Reduce Anxiety? *Art Therapy*, 22(2), 81–85. doi.org/10.1080/07421656.2005.10129441
- **Colouring.** van der Vennet, R., & Serice, S. (2012). Can Coloring Mandalas Reduce Anxiety? A Replication Study. *Art Therapy*. doi.org/10.1080/07421656.2012.680047
- **Colouring and art therapy.** Art Therapy Group: Coloring Books Are Great, But ..., Associations Now (2016), reporting the American Art Therapy Association's statement. associationsnow.com/2016/05/art-therapy-group-coloring-books-great
- **Giving back.** Tibetan Healing Mandala, Smithsonian National Museum of Asian Art. asia-archive.si.edu/tibetan-healing-mandala
- **Seed that belongs.** The sources for each region are listed with it in the Seed Atlas. seedlingpages.ca/seed-atlas.html

